

bombsights were considered so vital a secret device that between missions they were removed from aircraft and kept under armed guard. Bombardiers had strict orders to destroy them before bailing out if shot down over enemy territory. But the Norden bombsight was so sophisticated that only a highly trained bombardier could operate it successfully. The USAAF soon adopted a system in which only the lead bomber of the formation had the bombsight; the other bombers in the formation dropped their bombs when he did. But even the best of bombardiers needed to be able to see the target to use the bombsight. Cloud, mist, and smoke could wreak havoc with bombing accuracy.

Through 1943 the USAAF daylight offensive gathered momentum, launched from bases not only in England but also in North Africa and, later, in Italy. But the bombers took heavy punishment. For instance, on August 17, 1943, B-17s from bases in England carried out simultaneous raids on the ball-bearing factory in Schweinfurt and the aircraft factory in Regensburg. Of 376 aircraft that set out on the dual mission, 60 were shot

CURTIS LEMAY

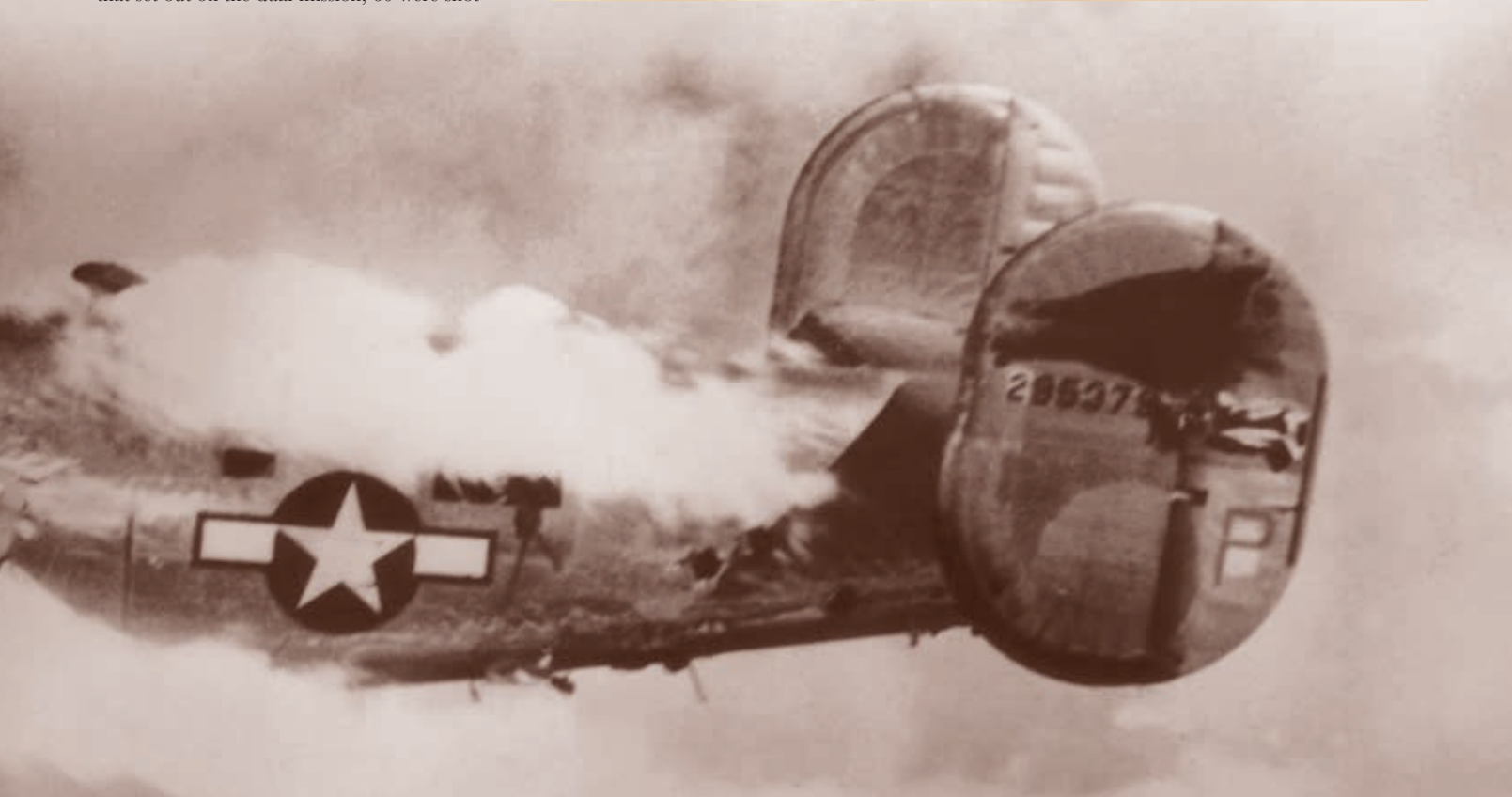
GENERAL CURTIS LEMAY (1906–90) was known as the toughest officer in the USAAF – his men were reputed to look forward to a spell in an enemy prisoner-of-war camp as a soft option compared with working for “Old Iron Ass.”

It was a toughness that brought results. LeMay had been born on the wrong side of the tracks, and forged a path into the air force and up through its ranks by hard work and willpower. He took the B-17s of 305th Bomb Group to England in the fall of 1942 and proved his outfit the most effective in the “Mighty Eighth,” with the tightest bomb pattern and lowest losses. He transferred to the Pacific theater in 1944 and personally led missions against Japan to take stock of the task.

TOUGH LEADER

As head of US Strategic Air Command in the early years of the Cold War, LeMay's hawkish personality contributed to the credibility of nuclear deterrence – here was a man who was definitely ready, if required, to unleash nuclear war.

He devised the strategy of low-level night incendiary raids that reduced Japanese cities to ashes in the spring of 1945. After the war LeMay commanded the US nuclear bomber force. In the 1960s he was involved in right-wing politics, famously threatening the North Vietnamese with being “bombed back to the Stone Age.”



FIERY DEATH

A B-24 Liberator erupts in flames in a raid over Austria in 1944. The USAAF photographer who took the picture said: “I felt guilty, helplessly snapping a death picture while the men were burning inside.”